

NATURAL GAS



What a whiff!

Natural gas has no smell. Chemicals are added to it so that leaks can be smelled.

In 1918, a gas was discovered in an oilfield in Texas. It was named natural gas because it replaced a gas that was manufactured from coal. This new fuel is now used in factories and homes all over the world. Natural gas travels a long way before it reaches your stove, to burn as a bright blue flame. It has to be released from deep below the ground, cleaned, and piped countless miles.



Mostly methane

Natural gas contains three different gases. Butane and propane are taken out at a gas terminal. Methane, the part that burns best, is sent through pipes to houses and factories.



Butane gas camping stove

Cool it

Ships take methane to places that are not connected to pipelines. The gas is cooled into a liquid so that it takes up 600 times less room.



If it is cooled into a liquid, a balloonful of methane gas can fit into a space the size of a pea.

Methane is cooled to -260°F (-162°C) to make it turn into a liquid.

Methane tank



The journey begins at a gas rig.

Gas terminal

Giant fans waft natural gas along the pipes.

Pipe

"Pig"



Soil

Very important pig

"Pigs," not people, check natural gas pipes!

A "pig" is a computer on wheels that whizzes down pipes to pinpoint cracks and other problems.